



PRESERVING THE IDENTITY
Bhikha Behram Well at Churchgate; (below) Framji Dadabhoy Alpaiwalla Museum in Kharegat Colony

Parsis, Zoroastrian immigrants from what was once Persia, have contributed much to the warp and weft of Mumbai's fabric. But what does it mean to be a Parsi today? Three recent celebrations of their culture will help to understand the community's ethos better.

WHERE HOPE AND FAITH WELL

Waternamah, a gorgeous new book put together by Bachi Karkaria, inimitable author and chronicler of Mumbai, is centred around the Bhikha Behram Well at Churchgate. The book captures the well's atmosphere and extends its scope to encompass the universal sacred and secular significance of water through the eyes of various experts. While non-Parsis cannot enter this sacred space since its stained-glass panels were vandalised by miscreants in 2004, we can nevertheless admire its beauty while passing by. The well has been restored by conservation architect Kirtida Unwalla in 1999 and again in 2023.

Karkaria, a regular visitor to the well, speaks about the 300-year-old structure's serenity despite being in the bustling heart of the city. "Touching its stone, I get an instant connect with history and community," she says. "The well feels like a friend I can casually drop in on without ritual formalities. I walk in, give a token contribution, light a *divo* (lamp), say a short prayer and then lose track of time gazing into its dark depths, fascinated by the terrapins paddling on the surface, and the silver and gold fish which silently surface."

Parsis believe a divine voice came to 18th-century merchant Bhikha Behram Panday in a recurrent dream, commanding him to build a well at that specific spot. The phenomenon of its sweet water despite its seashore location adds to the mystique of how Zoroastrianism's powerful water spirit, Ardvisura Anahita, grants the wishes of those who pray to her here. On the auspicious day of Avan Roz (usually around March every year), the city's Zoroastrians worship this powerful yazata.

THE 'GATEWAY' RETURNS TO GIRGAON

Girgaon is where the next stop on our story of Parsi revival takes us. To the recent restoration and reinstallation of the 'Parsi Gate' on Marine Drive. Dedicated to yazata Avan, this is also an important spot where people pay her respect. The two obelisks built of Malad sandstone that date back more than a hundred years, each five metres tall and bearing Zoroastrian motifs, were removed in April 2021 when the construction of the coastal road began. The process of replacing them 75 metres to the north of their original location (so that the canopy to the entrance of the underwater segment of the coastal road does not block the view of these columns) started after its completion last year. The newly built steps and the refurbished pillars stand testament to the enduring faith of the Parsi community and the intertwining of their fate with the city.



WATERNAMAH: 300 Years of Mumbai's Bhikha Behram Well 1725-2025
Edited by Bachi Karkaria
THE BHIKHA BEHRAM WELL TRUST
₹750; 151 pages

A MUSE AND A MUSEUM ON MALABAR HILL

Lastly, we stop by the freshly reopened Framji Dadabhoy Alpaiwalla Museum in Kharegat Colony at the foot of Mumbai's tony Malabar Hill. It was first set up by the Bombay Parsi